

A RED BOOK, AND A RED CAPPUCCINO

A Standalone Novella of the Shorigan Cycle

The Library does not keep its stories the way a vault keeps money. It keeps them the way a web keeps rain.

I. The Asking



There is a rule older than the Library itself, and it is this: a door opened for you is not the same door you would have opened for yourself. It leads to the same room. It costs a different price.

Alexander had learned, by now, to ask what things cost before he agreed that they were free.



He found Isor where Isor was always found, which is to say nowhere in particular, at exactly the moment the question had finished forming and not one breath before. This was, Alexander had come to understand, not magic. It was punctuality of a kind so old it had stopped needing clocks.

They stood at a threshold in the Dream Realm that was not quite Alexander's and not quite anyone else's — one of those seams the Realm kept the way a coat keeps its pockets, present the whole time, noticed only when a hand goes looking. Below them, or behind them, or in some direction the waking grammar of space had no preposition for,

the ordinary machinery of Alexander's night went on without him: the sea he always dreamed badly, the corridor of doors he had long ago stopped opening, the small stubborn light he kept burning in the corner of every dream the way some men keep a candle in a window for no one they can name.

"I want to ask permission," Alexander said.

"You have never needed my permission to be foolish," Isor said. "You have managed several notable foolishnesses entirely unsupervised."

"That's why I'm asking. The last few doors I walked through, I walked through by accident. I wanted, once, to walk through one on purpose. With the owner watching."

Isor turned to look at him then, and the look was the whole interview. Isor did not examine people the way the Sight examined them, reading seam and thread. He looked at a person the way weather looks at a field — without agenda, and completely.

"You want the Library," he said.

"I want to meet Anansi."

The name did not echo. Names in the Dream Realm never echoed; they landed, and stayed landed, and made a small permanent dent in the night exactly the size of themselves. Alexander had learned that too, and learned it the hardest way available, and the learning was part of why he was here.

"Not to gain anything," he said, before Isor could ask, because he had rehearsed this part, and because rehearsing things for Isor was famously useless and he did it anyway. "Not to be tested. Not to prove I've earned it. I don't think I have earned it. I want to learn from the one teller who never pretended his stories were free."

"And the other reason," Isor said.

Alexander was quiet for a moment. Under his arm, where it had been every night for longer than he could account for, the red book pressed its familiar corner into his ribs — the notebook he had kept since before he

understood what he was keeping it for, its cover gone soft at the spine, its elastic long ago replaced with string.

"Something is happening to me," he said. "I don't know what. I've stopped trusting the people who answer that question quickly."

"Good," Isor said. "Then you are finally ready to ask it of someone who won't."

He did not gesture. Doors, for Isor, were not opened; they were conceded. The threshold in front of them stopped pretending to be a seam and admitted it had been a doorway all along, and through it Alexander could see — not shelves, not yet, but the particular quality of light that only exists in rooms where a great deal has been read.

"One thing," Isor said, as Alexander stepped forward. "When he offers you tea, take it. When he offers you a story, take it. When he offers you a bargain—"

"Refuse it?"

"Count your pockets first," Isor said. "Then decide. He has never once cheated anyone who counted."

Alexander stopped, half through the door. "You know him."

Isor's expression did not change, which was itself a kind of answer, the way a locked drawer is a kind of inventory.

"Go and learn," he said. "Come back hungry. If you come back full, you'll have learned nothing."

And then the threshold was behind Alexander, and the light of much-read rooms was around him, and Isor was, in the manner of the greatest teachers, already gone — having taught, as usual, almost nothing, and arranged everything.



II. The Front Desk



The Library is not a building. Buildings are built once. The Library is built every time someone reads honestly, and unbuilt a little every time someone quotes what they never understood.



It did not look the way Alexander had allowed himself to imagine it, which he took, correctly, as a good sign.

There were shelves, but the shelves did not behave. They ran in long colonnades that turned out, when walked, to be single shelves seen from different years. There was no catalogue. There were no sections. Nothing here was organized by continent or century, because the Library did not believe in continents or centuries; it believed in tellings, and a telling belongs to whoever is inside it at the time. A hunting story from a savannah stood spine to spine with a hunting story from a fjord, and the two had clearly been talking.

There were other figures in the aisles — some browsing, some shelved. Alexander understood, without being told, that the distinction was not permanent. Every teller who had ever lived here had also, at some point, been lived in. None of them looked up. None of them demanded anything. That was the second thing he noticed about the Library, after the light: nothing in it asked to be worshipped. Everything in it pointed somewhere past itself, the way a good sentence points past its own grammar at the thing it was built to carry.

The front desk was small, and wooden, and slightly sticky on one corner as though honey had been spilled there sometime in the last thousand years and imperfectly regretted.

The spider sat on it, in it, around it — Alexander's eyes kept renegotiating the arrangement. Sometimes an old man, thin as a bent nail, in a robe the colour of dust that has seen better festivals. Sometimes a spider the size of a hand, each leg resting on the desk with the fussy precision of a bank clerk's fingers. Mostly, and most truly, both at once, in the way a word can be both its sound and its meaning without either agreeing to go first.

"You took your time," Anansi said. "Forty years, give or take. I had tea ready in your thirties, but you were busy."

"You knew I was coming?"

"I know everyone is coming. It saves on surprise." He tipped his head — or the spider raised two legs; the gesture translated either way. "Isor sent you."

"He opened a door. He didn't say he knew you."

"He wouldn't." Anansi's smile arrived sideways, the way his warmth would always arrive, never head-on, like sun coming into a room off a whitewashed wall. "He still owes me an ending. He's been owing it so long the interest is now worth more than the story. Neither of us mentions it. It's the politest debt I hold."

He poured the tea without being seen to have a kettle. It tasted of something Alexander could not place, which he would later understand was the point: it tasted of the first time he had ever been told a story and believed it.

"So," Anansi said. "You've come to the Library, to the desk, to me, carrying a question so heavy you've wrapped it in a smaller question to make it portable. Ask the small one first. It's traditional."

Alexander had prepared several small questions. Standing here, he found he had no interest in any of them.

"What did it cost you," he said, "to own your stories?"

Anansi went still.

It was the stillness Alexander would learn to watch for over everything that followed — not the stillness of a man surprised, but the stillness of a spider, which is a working stillness, total and patient and precisely as long as stillness stays useful, and not one heartbeat longer.

"Ah," Anansi said softly. "You skipped the small question."

"I've been told I do that."

"Whoever told you meant it as a criticism. Take it as a diagnosis." He set down his tea. His eyes — however many there were at that moment — had stopped being merry, without becoming anything as simple as sad. "That question has a real answer, and the real answer is long, and I will give it to you the way I give everything: crooked, in instalments, with at least one part missing that you'll find in your pocket a year from now and wonder how it got there. Agreed?"

"Agreed."

"Then first," Anansi said, and his gaze dropped, frank and unembarrassed, to the red book under Alexander's arm, "a matter of protocol. What's the red one?"

"Mine."

"Everything in this Library was 'mine' once. May I see it?"

"No," Alexander said.

He had not planned to say it. The word was out before courtesy could dress it, flat and complete, and for a moment he braced the way a man braces after dropping a plate in a quiet house.

Anansi laughed.

It was not the laugh of a performance — Alexander had heard plenty of those, had performed a few — but a real one, brief and delighted, with teeth in it, gently.

"Good," said the owner of every story ever told about himself. "A man who lends his book on the first day has never read it. Keep your no. Keep it warm. You'll need it several more times before you leave, and once, near the end, you'll need to have used it up." He stood, and the desk was somehow behind them now, and an aisle of the Library was unrolling ahead of them like a sentence deciding on its verb. "Come. You asked what it cost. Everyone thinks the answer starts with the price. It doesn't. It starts with the shop."



III. The Shop Where Stories Were Kept Before Him



Every people remembers the day fire arrived. Almost no one remembers the day stories did. This is because fire arrived once. Stories arrive every time, and a thing that always arrives is impossible to celebrate and impossible to lose.



They walked, and the Library rearranged itself around the walking, and Anansi talked — not the way a lecturer talks, filling silence with content, but the way a fisherman pays out line: with slack in it, watching where it drifted.

"In the beginning," he said, "the stories belonged to Nyame. The Sky-God. All of them — every tale, every telling, every account of anything that had ever happened or been imagined to happen. He kept them the way the sky keeps everything: perfectly, and uselessly. A story in the sky is thunder. It impresses. It waters nothing."

"And the world below?"

"Was not silent. People spoke. They reported, they instructed, they warned. 'The river is high.' 'The leopard hunts at dusk.' 'Do not marry that man.' Useful noise. But there was no *and then*. Do you understand what I am telling you? There was no way of saying a thing that made a listener lean forward. Time passed, and everyone was inside it, and no one could hold a piece of it up to the light and turn it. A grief happened and then simply — sat there. Whole. Undigestible. Grief without story is a stone the body cannot pass."

He stopped at a shelf and touched one spine with the tenderness of a man touching a scar that has become a friend.

"I was not noble," he said. "Let the record show. I have heard tellings where I go up to Nyame out of pity for humankind, that poor storyless

herd, and those tellings are pretty, and I keep them on the shelf, and they are wrong. I went up because I wanted them. All of them. I was greedy the way only a small thing can be greedy — a big creature wants a bigger share; a small creature wants the whole pot, because a share, for the small, has never once been enough to survive on." He glanced at Alexander, sideways. "You will notice I have not stopped being small. Remember that later, when you're deciding whether to trust me. It's the only credential I have that can't be forged."

"What did Nyame say?"

"He laughed. A sky laughing is a whole season, you understand — I stood in that laughter and got rained on and sunburned and rained on again. Then he named his price, and the price was designed to be a refusal. Great kingdoms had come asking, he said. Warriors, chiefs, whole peoples with drums. He'd priced the stories out of every market that mattered, because a god who sells his treasure once can never again enjoy owning it. He asked me for Onini, the python who could argue a river out of its banks. For Osebo, the leopard whose teeth were the last thing forty villages had seen. For the Mmoboro, the hornets, who cannot be fought because they are not an animal, they are a weather. And for Mmoatia, the fairy, whom no one had ever caught because she is only real when she is angry."

"Four impossibilities."

"Four impossibilities, priced for kingdoms, quoted to a spider." Anansi resumed walking. "And here is the first instalment of your answer, so pay attention: the reason the price was payable at all is the reason it cost so much. I could not out-fight any of them. I could not out-run, out-climb, or out-frighten a single one. The only thing I had — the *only* thing, I want you to hear that word properly — was that I could tell each of them a story about themselves that they wanted to be true."

He counted them off, and as he counted, the aisle they were walking dimmed and warmed, as though the Library itself were leaning in.

"Onini, I found arguing with his wife about whether he was longer than a palm branch. I didn't trap him. I offered to *measure* him. He lay down along the branch himself, at his fullest, proudest stretch, and asked me to tie him to it so the measurement would be fair. Fair! He supplied the

word. I supplied the string. Osebo I found at the bottom of a pit he was too proud to call for help from, and I offered to lift him out with a web, and the web was a net before he was halfway up, and the last thing his pride said before it stopped talking was *higher*. The hornets I told a story about rain — a storm coming, terrible, and me with a dry calabash and a kind heart. They flew into shelter. The shelter had a lid. And Mmoatia—" he paused, and the pause had a shape, and the shape was not comic — "Mmoatia I caught with a doll covered in sticky gum, and a bowl of yam, and her own perfect, incorruptible sense of justice. The doll would not thank her for the yam. She struck it for its rudeness. She stuck. She struck it again with the other hand, because injustice, to her, was worth both hands. That is the one I don't retell often. It's a story about how the best thing in a creature can be the handle you carry her by, and I have never worked out how to make it funny, and I have never let anyone soften it, either."

They had stopped in a part of the Library with no shelves at all — an open floor, and above it, dim in the rafters, something vast and geometric that Alexander's eyes kept declining to resolve.

"I brought Nyame his price," Anansi said. "All four. Some tellings add a fifth thing — that I brought him my own mother, Ya Nsia, as interest. I will not tell you tonight whether that one is true. It stays on the shelf with the others, because that is the deal I made with myself the day the stories became mine: *everything stays on the shelf*. And Nyame stood up, and the sky stood up with him, and he announced to everything that lives that the stories now belonged to Kwaku Anansi, and would be called by my name for as long as tellings last. Anansesem. The spider's stories. Even the ones with no spider in them anywhere."

"That's the part everyone knows," Alexander said. "The trials. The purchase."

"Yes."

"It's not the answer to my question."

"No," Anansi agreed, and he sounded, for the first time, pleased in a way that had nothing sideways about it. "It is the shop, and the price tag, and the receipt. You asked what it *cost*. The cost began the moment the price was paid. Sit down, Alexander-who-skips-the-small-question. This

is the second instalment, and it is the one I have never managed to make short."



IV. The Cost



A man who owns one story is its teller. A man who owns every story is their address.



There were chairs on the open floor now, two of them, facing each other in the manner of chairs that have done this before. Alexander sat. Above them, in the rafters, the vast dim geometry stirred very slightly, the way a cathedral's dark stirs when the door opens far below.

"Understand what I bought," Anansi said. "Not a chest of tales. Not a library — this Library grew later, out of the purchase, the way a shell grows out of a snail. What I bought was the *right of ownership over telling itself*. Every story told anywhere, from that day on, is told on my land. A grandmother in a fishing village, a liar in a courtroom, a boy comforting his brother in the dark with something he is making up as he goes — all of them, whether they have ever heard my name or not, are spinning on a corner of my web."

"That sounds like wealth."

"It is wealth. I never once said it wasn't; beware of any owner who cries poverty while sitting on the deed. It is wealth, and it is beautiful, and I will not perform regret for you, because regret would be a lie and I do not lie about anything that matters." He leaned forward. "But hear the cost. Three strands of it. I have had a long time to count.

"The first strand: *I am everywhere, and I am never anywhere*. Every people that tells my stories has made their own Anansi. In one mouth I am a hero. In another, a pest. In a third, a god; in a fourth, a warning

against exactly the cleverness the third one worships. Children on islands my legs have never touched know my name in languages I learned by being spoken in. And every single one of those Anansis is partly true, and not one of them — not one, in all the tellings since the sky stood up — has ever been the whole of me. Do you know what it is to be perfectly famous and completely unmet? I am the most-known stranger who has ever existed. That is the first strand, and on bad centuries it is the heaviest."

Alexander thought, unbidden, of a woman who had spent twenty-seven years making sure no one could speak her correctly. He did not say so. He wrote nothing down. The red book stayed shut under his arm, and Anansi's eyes flicked to it, once, and away, in courteous acknowledgment of a door still closed.

"The second strand: *I own the tellings that shrink me*. This is the one your poets never price in. When Nyame gave me the stories, he gave me all of them — including every story in which I am a fool. And there are many, and more arrive every generation, because tellers are honest even when they don't mean to be, and I have earned every unflattering word. The pot of wisdom — you know it? — where I gathered all the wisdom in the world into one pot to hoard it, and tried to climb a tree with the pot slung in front of me, scraping and slipping, until my own small son called up: *Father, would it not be easier to tie the pot on your back?* And I looked at the pot of all the world's wisdom, and I looked at my boy, and I understood that the collection was already a failure, and I smashed it, and the wisdom went everywhere, into everyone, in unequal and unfair and unrecalable portions, which is why no one has all of it and everyone has some.

"I own that story, Alexander. I could have unmade it. In the first century of the purchase, I confess I took it down off the shelf many nights and held it over the fire. A quieter version. A version where the smashing was the plan all along, where the trickster meant it, where the fool in the tree was only ever playing the fool. It would have been so easy. It would have been one night's work." His voice had gone quiet, and the quiet had gravel in it. "I put it back. Every time, I put it back. Because the day I improve one telling, the web stops being a record and becomes a costume — and a costume is the one thing a spider, of all creatures, must never mistake for skin. So the fool in the tree stays. He is load-

bearing. Take him out, and everything above him comes down, including the parts I'm proud of."

"And the third strand?"

Anansi looked up, into the rafters, at the vast dim geometry, and now, following his gaze, Alexander's eyes finally consented to see it: the Web itself, or the ghost or root or true-body of it, spanning the whole unseeable ceiling of the Library — strand over strand over strand, every thread anchored to a shelf, every shelf anchored to a telling, the entire architecture humming very faintly, like a struck instrument a thousand years after the note.

"The third strand is the one I will not say in a sentence," Anansi said. "Because I tried, for six hundred years, to say it in a sentence, and every sentence I built was beautiful, and every one of them was a wall around the thing rather than a window into it. So I will say it the only way it goes: the price Nyame named was four impossible creatures. The price I *paid* has no name, and I am still paying it, weekly, in a currency you have been carrying under your left arm since you walked in — and that, spider's honour, is all you get tonight."

He clapped his hands, or several of them, and the chairs were gone, and the tea was back, and his grin had returned from wherever grins go while the truth is being told.

"Now," he said. "You've had two instalments and a look at the ceiling. Protocol says you owe me a small question. Ask me something easy, Alexander. Ask me something a fool could answer. I find I need one."

And Alexander, who had come with a heavy question wrapped in a small one, heard himself ask the small one at last — the one he had been carrying so long it had worn smooth:

"Why does everyone call you Anansi, when Nyame said the stories would carry the name Kwaku Anansi?"

The spider went still again. The working stillness.

"Ah," he said. "You have a gift for easy questions that aren't."



V. Two Names



Ask a river its name and it will show you a fish. This is not evasion. It is the only fluent answer a river has.



"Kwaku," Anansi said, "is a born name. Where I am from — where the first tellings are from, which is as close to a from as I own — a boy born on a Wednesday is Kwaku. It is a name that says *when*. It fixes a person to a day, a mother, a compound, a particular rain. Kwaku is the name of someone who can be found."

"And Anansi?"

"Anansi is the word for spider. It is a name that says *what*. It fixes me to nothing. There are as many spiders as there are corners." He turned his tea slowly. "So. One name that makes me a someone, and one that makes me an anyone. And your easy question, correctly weighed, is: which one is true?"

"Yes."

"I decline," Anansi said pleasantly.

Alexander waited. Waiting, he had found, was the one lever that occasionally moved the immovable.

"You misunderstand — the refusal is the answer, or as much of one as exists. Watch." He held up one hand, or leg, fingers spread. "The tellings that call me Kwaku Anansi are the ones where I pay. Where the price is real, where the mother is real, where the Wednesday is real. The tellings that call me Anansi, only Anansi, are the ones where I get away with it — where I am appetite and cleverness with no compound to be dragged back to. Both sets of tellings are on my shelves. Both are load-bearing. If

I ruled tonight that one name was the true one, I would be unmaking the other half of the web, and I have already told you what I think of owners who improve their inventory."

"That's a very good answer," Alexander said slowly, "and it is not one."

"Correct on both counts." The grin, sideways. "Your Isor would say — has said, in fact, in a room neither of us will describe to you — that a name spoken correctly cannot be unheard. What he does not advertise is the corollary. A being can be too old, and too told, for there to remain a single correct speaking. Somewhere very far down, under the shelves, under the first telling, there was a Wednesday. There was a mother. There was a boy who did not yet own anything, not even a good lie. Whether that boy is still the true name of all this—" he gestured, with several limbs at once, at the desk, the aisles, the humming dim ceiling — "or only the first strand it was spun from, is a question I have decided, on the advice of the only counsel I trust, never to settle."

"Whose advice?"

"Mine," said Anansi. "Obviously. Now stop pulling that thread; it's attached to me. Come back tomorrow night. You've had the shop, the price, the receipt, and a name and a half. Tomorrow, if you're brave and you bring your own tea, I'll show you how the web *works* — and you'll want your book for that one, even if you keep it shut."



VI. The Grammar of Webs



Nothing in a web is decoration. Learn that sentence. It is the least poetic sentence in this whole account, and it is the one to keep.



Alexander came back the next night, and the night after, and the nights began to run together the way nights do when the days between them

lose the argument.

He kept his waking life in order — worked, ate, returned his messages, sat some evenings in a certain unnamed room at the seam of two people's dreaming where a kettle boiled that never needed filling, and said nothing there, yet, about the Library, because he did not have the shape of it ready to hand to anyone, and because handing over unfinished shapes was a habit he was trying, on medical advice from no doctor, to unlearn.

And in the Library, Anansi taught. Or rather, Anansi *talked while working*, which Alexander came slowly to understand was the entire pedagogy.

The work was the web. Not the vast dim archive in the rafters — that one, Anansi said, tended itself now, the way a language tends itself — but small webs, working webs, spun nightly in the corners of the Library between shelf and shelf, between one telling and another that had never been introduced.

"Look," Anansi said, hanging upside down with the unselfconsciousness of a being for whom down was a rumor. "What is a web?"

"A trap."

"Spoken like a fly. Try again."

"A home. A net. A—"

"You are listing uses. I asked what it *is*." He touched one radial strand, and the whole structure answered, every joint passing the news along. "A web is grammar made visible. It is the only place in creation where you can see syntax — walk up to it, put your eye close, watch meaning bear weight. Every strand is a clause. Every anchor point is a premise: this shelf holds, that beam holds, the world may be trusted *here* and *here*, provisionally, tonight. Every junction — look, this one — is where two clauses meet and agree to be responsible for each other. That junction is load-bearing. If it fails, it does not fail alone; it hands its load to its neighbours, and either they hold, and the web survives smaller, or they don't, and you learn which of your sentences was actually carrying the roof."

"And the spiral?"

"The spiral is rhetoric," Anansi said, with a touch of professional distaste. "The sticky part. The part that catches. Necessary — I have never once pretended persuasion wasn't necessary — but hear me, because this is the lesson your kind reliably gets backwards: *the spiral is hung on the radials, never the reverse*. The catching-thread is the last thing spun, not the first. A web that is all spiral and no frame catches one fly and comes down with it. And a teller who is all persuasion and no premise—"

"—catches one listener and comes down with him."

"Now you are talking like a spider." Anansi swung right side up. "Your masked friends in the manuals — yes, I read them; everything written ends up on my shelves eventually, including the instructional literature, which files itself under *tellings that deny being tellings* — your manuals say action has a grammar. Voice, mood, tense, aspect. They are right, and I could have saved them several chapters. Spinning is the middle voice, the purest case of it anywhere: the spider makes the web, and the web remakes the spider's world, and by morning it is not possible to say where the animal ends and the architecture begins. A web is *I did, I am doing, I will have done*, all three tenses standing in the same silk. The finished strands are *I did* — load-bearing, unrevisable without cost. The strand in the spinnerets is *I am doing*. And the empty corner the whole night's work is already reaching toward, the anchor point chosen before there is any thread to reach it—"

"*I will have done*."

"The future perfect," Anansi said. "The trickster's home tense. Every scheme I have ever run was conjugated there. You do not spin toward where the fly is, Alexander. You spin toward where the fly *will have been*." He let the silence sit for exactly one beat. "That is also, since you have not asked, how one approaches a story. You will want that sentence later. I am giving it to you now so that later it will already be yours."

Alexander wrote nothing down. But that night, for the first time in the Library, he *wanted* to — felt the old pull of the red book, the pen, the recording habit — and noticed the want, and noticed himself declining it, and did not yet ask himself why declining it felt less like discipline and

more like hiding.

Anansi, hanging in his web, watched him not-write with the expression of a clockmaker listening to a tick arrive fractionally late, and said nothing, and filed it.



VII. Niss



Some words are keys cut before their locks. Language keeps them anyway. Language has always been sentimental about its orphans.



It was many nights in — past the point where either of them was counting — when Alexander brought the word.

He had been carrying it longer than he had been carrying the question about the stories; longer, possibly, than the red book, though the book was where it had first surfaced, years ago, alone at the top of an otherwise empty page, in his own handwriting, with no memory attached of having written it. He had never said it aloud to anyone. Saying a thing aloud to Anansi, he had learned, was not like saying it aloud to anyone.

They were at the desk. The Library was in its smallest hour, the aisles gone soft and municipal, and Anansi was doing something fussy and contented to the sticky corner with a cloth that never got cleaner.

"There's a word," Alexander said.

"There are several. I've been collecting them."

"This one I don't think you have."

The cloth stopped. Everything about Anansi came slowly, politely, entirely to attention, the way a web comes to attention: no visible

movement, total reallocation.

"Say it," he said.

"Niss."

The word landed the way names landed — made its small permanent dent in the night exactly the size of itself — and then did something Alexander had never seen a word do. It sat there. It did not unfold into meaning. It did not reach for its neighbours. It sat in the middle of the air between them like a seed with no opinion about soil.

"Say it again," Anansi said, in a changed voice.

"Niss."

"Where did you get it?"

"I don't know. I wrote it down before I knew I was writing it. I've spent years trying to catch it in a definition and every definition dies on the table. The closest I've come—" Alexander hesitated, because the closest he'd come sounded, outside his own head, like either poetry or symptom, and he no longer trusted himself to know which. "The closest I've come is that it's the *inside* of a thing. Not the essence — essence is already a philosopher's word, it comes with furniture. Before that. The suchness. The interior fact of a thing that is there before any description arrives and still there after every description fails. And—" he pushed on, into the part he had never said even silently in an orderly way — "I think it might already be *in* the language. Hidden. Happiness. Sadness. Kindness. Stillness. Wholeness. We say the suffix means 'the state of being' — but suppose it's not a suffix. Suppose '-ness' is the fossil of a whole word, an old full word, and every abstract noun we have is a compound we forgot was a compound. Happy-*ness*. The niss of being happy. As if language has been pointing at something, over and over, millions of times a day in a hundred tongues, for so long that the pointing wore smooth and everyone stopped seeing the finger."

Silence. Real silence — the Library's hum had stepped out of the room.

"I am going to try something," Anansi said at last, "that I have not tried in a very long time, because it has not failed in a very long time. I am going

to catch it. That is what I do, Alexander. That is what the whole web is. There has never been a truth too large for hands that a story could not be spun around — that is not boasting, it is my trade, it is the one thing the smallest creature in the room has always been able to do that the sky itself could not. So. Watch closely. If it works, you will have your definition. If it doesn't—" his grin flickered, and under it, for half a heartbeat, was something Alexander had no name for yet, and would later decide had been *hope* — "if it doesn't, you will have something considerably better."

And Anansi told a story.

Alexander could never afterward reproduce it, and his failure to reproduce it was not a failure of memory. It was a story about a village where everything had two names, its market name and its true name, and a girl who discovered a third category — things whose true names had never been collected, not because the names were hidden but because the things had come into the world before the naming-office opened and had simply never filed. It was funnier than it had any right to be. It had a talking calabash in it, and a tax dispute, and a scene at a border crossing between two kinds of silence. And it was, Alexander understood, watching it happen, not entertainment: it was *engineering*. Every joke was an anchor point. Every image was a radial. The whole telling was a web, spun in real time, in narrowing spirals, around the still point in the middle of the air where the word sat — closer, and closer, every strand placed with six hundred years of craft, until the last spiral turn was so tight that the story and the word were nearly touching, and the story reached out its final sentence to stick—

—and the word was not there.

It had not moved. That was the unaccountable part, the part Alexander would turn over for years. Niss had not dodged, had not fled down some gap in the logic. It was still exactly where it had been, in the middle of the finished web, unstuck, untouched, the way the hole in the middle of a wheel is untouched by the wheel. The story had caught, perfectly, the whole shape of everything *around* the word. The word itself sat in the centre of the catch, unowned, mildly present, like a guest who has not noticed the party is in his honour.

Anansi stared at it.

Then he began to laugh.

It started low, disbelieving, one register down from his speaking voice, and it climbed, and it did not stop when laughter usually stops; it went on past performance, past politeness, into the true helpless territory, and he had to sit down on his own desk, and several of his legs were not cooperating, and when he finally got words out they came in pieces.

"Six hundred — *six hundred years* — oh, this is — do you know — Alexander, do you know what you have — " He wiped at his eyes, all of them, in stages. "I caught the python with his own pride. I caught the hornets with the *idea* of rain. I have spun webs around death, around debt, around the difference between what a king says and what a king means — there was nothing, nothing in the whole inventory, that could not be caught, because everything that exists casts a story, and where there is a story there is an anchor point. And you have walked into my Library, on borrowed permission, with your book you won't show me, carrying — *this*." He pointed at the word with a trembling and delighted limb. "A word with no story. Not a hidden story. *None*. Nothing casts from it. It is not before its meaning, like a young word. It is not after its meaning, like a dead one. It is — it is *upstream* of story entirely, and I have just spent the finest web of my career learning that my silk does not go upstream."

"Then what is it?" Alexander said. "If you can't catch it — you, of everyone — then what am I carrying?"

Anansi's laughter settled, though the light of it stayed on in his face, and when he answered, his voice had in it something Alexander had not heard from him before and understood at once was rarer than the laughter: plain, unhandled wonder, with no thread attached.

"I don't know," said the owner of every story ever told. "I don't know, and I cannot remember the last time I got to say that and mean it, and I would not sell this evening for the whole of Nyame's sky." He looked at the word, sitting patient and small in the ruins of the best story never to work. "Here is everything I can honestly give you, and notice, please, that it is a description of my failure and not of your word. Every catchable thing casts story the way a body casts shadow. Your word casts none —

which means either it is not a thing, or it is the kind of thing that shadows are cast *onto*. Not an object in the web. Something the web is spun *against* — the way silk is spun against air. No spider catches air. But no web has ever once stood without it."

He stood, and did something Alexander had never seen: he left the failed web where it hung. Did not eat it back, did not clear it. Left it, with the word in the middle, like a monument, or a question mark built at architectural scale.

"Leave it there," Anansi said quietly. "I want to be wrong about something in a place where I can visit it. It keeps the inventory honest. Now go home, boy. You've done enough damage to my reputation for one—"

He stopped. His head tilted.

"You've stopped writing," he said.

The change of subject had no seam in it at all, which is how Alexander knew it was not a change of subject.

"What?"

"Your book. The red one. You wanted it, the night I showed you the tenses — I watched the want go through you like weather. You've wanted it a dozen nights since. You never open it. A man carries a book every night into the one Library in creation and never once writes in it or reads from it." The sideways warmth was there, but underneath it the working stillness had come back, total and patient. "I asked to see it on the first night, and your no was good, and I told you to keep it warm. I am asking again. Not to read it. One page, Alexander. You choose which. Trickster's terms: I will tell you one true thing about what I see, only one, and you may not ask a second."

The Library held very still.

And Alexander — who had refused this easily once, in the doorway of everything, before he knew what he was refusing — found that the no was no longer where he had left it. He had, as promised, used it up: on definitions that died on the table, on the pull of the pen, on every night

he had declined the book without asking himself why. What remained where the no had been was only the fear, standing there with nothing left in front of it, and the fear, examined in the light of a web that could not catch air, turned out to be smaller than its shadow.

He took the elastic off the red book, and the string, and opened it, and turned it around on the desk.



VIII. One Page



The most dangerous reader is not the one who finds your secret. It is the one who finds your habit.



The page Alexander chose was not a secret. That was the point of choosing it; he was cornered, not stupid. It was an ordinary page from an ordinary year — a Tuesday, by internal evidence — dense with his small exact handwriting: an account of a colleague's dispute and how it had resolved; a line about the light on a wet street; three sentences on a dream not his own that he had walked out of carrying less of himself than he'd walked in with, recorded matter-of-factly, between the weather and a debt he was owed and would never call in. Nothing on the page would have raised an eyebrow at a border. He had chosen it the way a man being searched offers his emptiest pocket.

Anansi read it in the time it takes to read a page, and then read it again in the time it takes to read a person, and then sat back.

"One true thing," he said. "As agreed. Are you ready?"

"No," Alexander said. "Go on."

"There is no spider in this web."

Alexander waited for the rest. There was no rest. That, apparently, was the one true thing, whole and spent.

"I don't—"

"You may not ask a second," Anansi said, gently, and then relented exactly as far as a trickster relents, which is to say he restated the first thing with the price already paid. "I have read one page of a book kept nightly for — what, thirty years? Longer. One page, chosen by its keeper as the safest in the house. And on that safest page: a dispute, rendered fairly. A street, seen truly — that line about the light is better than you know, by the way; it will humiliate a professional someday. A healing, performed and paid for out of your own pocket and *entered in the ledger as weather*. Every strand on this page holds, Alexander. Every clause is load-bearing, every anchor honest, the grammar clean as good silk. It is an excellent web. And the animal that spun it appears nowhere in it. No *I did*. Not once — I looked twice. Things occur. Things resolve. Help arrives, unattributed, like rain. The teller has spun himself out of every strand so completely that a stranger reading this book — and I am the best-qualified stranger who will ever read it — could reconstruct the whole world around a man and never once meet him."

He turned the book back around, and closed it, with a courtesy that was worse than any violation would have been, and pushed it across the desk.

"You asked me, the first night, what it cost to own my stories," Anansi said. "And I gave you the shop, and the price, and two strands of the cost, and I told you the third strand could not go in a sentence, and that you were carrying its currency under your left arm. Here is the third strand, as far as words take it. When Nyame stood up and gave the stories my name, the name was not a trophy, boy. It was the *terms*. The stories became mine on the condition that I be *in* them — findable, blamable, laughable, small — in every telling, forever, including the ones where the fool cannot climb the tree. That is what owning a story is. It has never been anything else. Not possession. *Signature*. The story is yours exactly as far as your name is nailed to it where everyone can see, and not one strand further."

"And a story with no name nailed to it?"

"Is not owned. It is only *occurring*." Anansi's voice stayed level, and the levelness was the mercy. "Your book is thirty years of the finest unowned telling I have ever read a page of. You have been paying an owner's costs, Alexander — nightly, in attention, in exactness, in silk — and taking none of an owner's title. Now tie the pot on your back and hear the question you actually walked in here carrying, all those nights ago, wrapped in the question about me."

Alexander heard his own voice come out very quietly, and reluctantly, the way a splinter comes out.

"What is happening to me?"



IX. What Is Happening to You



Every true question spends its whole life disguised as a different question. The disguise is not cowardice. It is cocoon.



Anansi did not answer quickly.

This in itself was information; Alexander had watched him field questions about death, debt, and the sky with the reflexes of a creature that had never once been caught flat-footed by an inquiry. Now he got up from the desk and walked a little way down the nearest aisle, trailing one hand along the spines the way a man trails a hand in water off the side of a boat, and when he spoke it was not, at first, an answer.

"When a telling is repeated often enough," he said, "it stops being an event and becomes a place. You can live in a story. Most people do — a story about their family, their luck, their failure, told so many times the walls set. This is not sickness. It is architecture; your masked manuals call the working of it Memistry, and they are right to teach it with warnings on the label. And here is the part the manuals do not say,

because the manuals are written by the eye and this part belongs to the desk: *the traffic runs in both directions*. People live in stories. And stories, given time and enough honest tellings, live in people. I am the proof. I began — perhaps; ask the Wednesday — as a someone. I am now also a place. Every teller who tells me builds me. I told you it was the first strand of the cost: everywhere, and nowhere. Perfectly famous, completely unmet."

He stopped, and turned, and looked at Alexander down the aisle, and the look had no trick in it anywhere.

"You are becoming a teller, Alexander. Not a hobbyist. The real trade. It is in the book, it is in the healing, it is in the way you carried that word in here like a coal in a cupped hand. Something in you has been apprenticing to this desk since before you knew the desk existed. *That* is what is happening to you — the trade arriving — and the trade is a glory, and I will not let you refuse it out of fright. But the trade has two apprenticeships, and you have been serving only one. You have learned to spin. You have not learned to sign. And a teller who spins without signing does not stay a someone who owns no stories. Given years — and you have been given years — he becomes a place where stories happen. A room. A hallway. Everyone's weather and no one's rain. You have stood in dreams that were not yours and paid out of yourself and written it down as climate. There are people — I think there is at least one person — who could walk every corridor of you praising the architecture and never once meet the architect, and the worst of it, the strand I am pulling *hard* now, boy, is that you have been calling this humility, and it has humility's face, and it is the oldest counterfeit in my whole inventory."

"Then what is it?"

"Hiding," Anansi said. "Hiding of a very high order. The finest I've seen. You hide the way I catch — natively, brilliantly, and at cost. A man can vanish into a lie; that is cheap, and it is found out. You have been vanishing into *accuracy*. Into service. Into the third person. Nobody hunts for a man there, because nobody believes a man would choose it." He came back down the aisle and stood across the desk, and the lamplight, or what did the work of lamplight, made his face for a moment entirely an old man's, and entirely a spider's, both at once, without

contradiction. "I told you the first night I have never lied about anything that mattered. So attend: I am not telling you to fill your book with confession. Confession is just hiding with the lights on; I have shelves of it. I am telling you the terms of the trade you are already in. The stories you are becoming will be yours on one condition — the same condition, the only condition, the one the sky set me. That you be in them. Findable. Blamable. Laughable. *Small*, Alexander — small enough to be met. The web can be as vast as you have silk for. The spider stays spider-sized. That is not the web's limitation."

He smiled then, sideways, the warmth arriving off the whitewashed wall.

"It is its address."



X. Leaving



No one is discharged from a library. You are only ever issued.



There was no ceremony, in the end, because Anansi did not believe in endings that knew they were endings — "a story that announces its own last line has been lying since its first" — and so the last night in the Library was shaped like any other night until, gradually, it wasn't.

They drank the tea. They visited the failed web, where the word still sat, patient, unowned, in the middle of the finest wrong story of a long career; Anansi had taken to greeting it, formally, the way one greets a distinguished colleague from a rival firm. They argued, briefly and enjoyably, about whether the line about light on the wet street was better than Alexander knew (it was; he would learn this the hard way, in print, years later, exactly as promised). And at the desk, at the hour the aisles went soft, Anansi said, "You'll want to go home now," in the tone of a man reporting weather rather than issuing a dismissal, and Alexander found that it was true.

"Instalments," Alexander said. "You promised at least one part missing. Something I'd find in my pocket a year from now."

"So I did. It's already there. Don't check; you'll bruise it." Anansi walked him down the last aisle, past shelves that had stopped rearranging themselves, as though the Library, too, had decided to hold still for this. "Two things, and then the door. First: when you see Isor, tell him the ending he owes me has started accruing at the new rate. He'll know what it means. It will annoy him for a decade, which is, between old friends, the only gift that keeps."

"And the second thing?"

Anansi stopped at the threshold. Beyond it Alexander could feel, already, the ordinary machinery of his night idling — the badly dreamed sea, the corridor, the small stubborn light.

"The second thing you won't understand yet," Anansi said, "so put it in the book verbatim and let it age. Here it is. *A story told correctly is a kind of ownership — but the correction runs backward.* You will spend a while thinking that sentence is about technique. It is not about technique." He held out his hand — a hand, this time, unambiguously, an old man's hand, thin and warm and strong as wire. Alexander took it. "It was a good failure you brought me, boy. The best in six hundred years. Come back when you've been wrong about something that size yourself; you'll be twice the company."

"Is that likely?"

"It is," said Kwaku Anansi, "guaranteed. It's in the trade description. Now go home. And Alexander—" the grin, one last time, teeth in it, gently — "eat something. You've been full of everyone else for years. Go and be hungry as yourself. It's how the good ones always leave."

The door did what doors do.



XI. A Red Cappuccino



The Library has one exit, and it is everywhere, and it is called morning.



He woke hungry.

Not the metaphor. The plain animal fact, arriving before his eyes were properly open: a hollowness under the ribs with no philosophy in it at all, the body filing its oldest and most honest report. He lay still in the grey early light and took an inventory that had nothing of the Sight in it, because he had no Sight, had never had it, had only ever had the plain unguarded attention of a man — and the inventory came back ordinary. Two arms. The ceiling. Rain finishing up outside, unhurried, like someone reading the last page slowly. A whole night behind him that he could not verify one strand of.

That was the first thing he sat with, at the café on the corner an hour later, at the small table by the window with its one short leg and its folded coaster of long standing. He could not verify it. Any of it. There was no test he could run, no witness he could call — Isor did not testify, and the Realm kept no minutes — nothing to establish whether he had spent those nights in the interior architecture of a cultivated imagination, or in a hallucination of unusual craftsmanship, or in a symbolic truth his own mind had staged because he needed it, or in the workshop of an actual immortal appetite who had actual tea. He had asked, once, near the end, fishing, and Anansi had answered the way Anansi answered everything: *"You're asking whether to trust me. Wrong question. Trust the web to be a web. A web never once pretends to be the sky — that's the sky's trick. Ask instead whether the weight-bearing strands bear weight. Then stand on them, one at a time, and keep your book handy."*

It was not a comfort. He examined it again in daylight, over the rim of the menu he wasn't reading, and confirmed the finding of the night: it was not a comfort, and it was not a trap, and it was better than either. It was a working instruction. Neither the man who believed everything nor the man who believed nothing had to test anything. Testing was the third way, the slow way, the one that made you get up in the morning and put your actual weight on the strand. Cultivation, someone in his life had once called it, or would call it, or was calling it right now in a manual he

hadn't read; the tenses of his life had stopped standing in single file, and he found he minded less than he ought.

The waitress knew him and did not know him — knew the table, the folded coaster, the order — and he heard himself change the order.

"Red cappuccino," he said. "Please."

Rooibos, pulled like espresso, capped with foam. The drink that carries the name of a thing it isn't and has long ago stopped apologizing. No caffeine in it, nothing to defend its title with; red where it should be brown, herb where it should be bean, called a cappuccino by everyone and contested by no one, because somewhere along the line the telling had simply won — had been repeated, cup by cup, in enough kitchens and corners, until the name stopped being a claim and became an address. He had ordered it a hundred times and never once seen it. Now it came down on the table in its white cup, red-gold at the rim where the foam thinned, and he looked at it the way Anansi had taught him to look at everything, which is to say: the way you look at a web with your eye up close, watching meaning bear weight.

A cup of it. Ordinary. Completely ordinary. That was the whole of the miracle and he refused, on principle, to inflate it: no light came off it, nothing in the room rearranged, the rain outside went on reading its last page. But the ordinariness had *interior* now — had suchness, had the thing he had carried into the Library at the top of an empty page — and he understood, sitting there with his hunger and his unverifiable education, that this was what had actually changed, the only thing, the entire haul. Not new sight. No new power; he had gone in wanting none and had, in the oldest trick of an honest house, been given none. Just this: the world had been handed back to him at its own true weight. The cup weighed what a cup weighs. It had taken forty years and a spider to make that astonishing.

He ate. Eggs, bread, the pleasure of salt — the body settling its accounts with a night spent elsewhere. And when the plate was gone he did the thing he had been circling since he woke, and took the red book out of his bag, and set it beside the cup, and looked at the two of them together — a red book, and a red cappuccino, his whole estate, the ledger and the world it had been keeping — and undid the string.

He found the sentence in his pocket exactly where Anansi had said it would be, though the year had taken one night to pass. *A story told correctly is a kind of ownership — but the correction runs backward.* He had copied it down verbatim, as instructed, and let it age for the length of one breakfast, and now, with the pen uncapped and the day's blank page open, it finished arriving. It was not about technique. It had never been about technique. You did not first tell the story correctly and thereby come to own it. You first *owned* it — put your name where the weight was, stood findable in the load-bearing joint, signed — and the correctness flowed backward from the signature into every strand, the way a web is only ever as true as the animal that will have to live on it. The stories could not be caught; he had watched the finest silk in creation fail against the smallest word in his book. They could only be spun toward — future perfect, the trickster's home tense — one anchor placed where you intend to have been.

Alexander looked at thirty years of exact, honest, unowned pages. Then he turned past all of them, to the day's blank page, and wrote one sentence, in the first person, and signed it — the first entry in the red book, in all its red years, with the spider in the web.

The foam on the cappuccino had begun its slow settling, the way foam does, without drama, each small chamber quietly conceding. And near the rim — for a moment, only a moment, in the thinning white — a line of it held: one fine strand, drawn across the red, taut and bright as silk with dew on it. It was foam. He knew it was foam. He did not mention it to the waitress, or to the rain, or later, to anyone; he did not need to, and that — not the strand, the not-needing — was how he knew the Library had let him keep something after all.

He smiled, drank, and turned the page — the blank one, the next one, the one every book keeps regardless of its colour — and somewhere between the lifting of the pen and its landing, in the small silence where every story actually lives, he was already spinning toward it.



— end —

for the shelf where the failed web hangs, and for the word still sitting in

it.